CaterTrades

The Complete Buyer's Guide to Catering Vehicles

Everything you need to know after purchasing your first food van — from registration to trading.

FREE GUIDE • 2026 EDITION

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About This Guide

This guide is designed to help first-time catering vehicle owners navigate the essential steps to get trading legally and successfully. All information is accurate as of March 2026.

1. Before You Start Trading

Legal Checklist

Before serving your first customer, you **must** have:

- ☐ Food business registration (FREE)
- ☐ Level 2 Food Hygiene Certificate (£10–£25)
- ☐ Food Safety Management System / SFBB pack (FREE)
- ☐ Gas Safety Certificate CP44 (£80–£150/year)
- ☐ Public Liability Insurance (from £65/year)
- ☐ Street Trading Licence OR private land permission
- ☐ Vehicle MOT and insurance

Timeline & Costs

Task	When	Cost
Food business registration	28 days before opening	FREE
Food hygiene training	Before opening	£10–£25
Gas safety certificate	Before first use	£80–£150
Insurance	Before trading	From £65/year
Street trading licence	4–8 weeks processing	£100–£500/year

⚠️ **Important:** Trading without proper registration and certificates can result in fines, prosecution, and closure of your business. Complete all requirements before serving any customers.

2. Food Business Registration

What It Is

All food businesses in the UK must register with their local council. This applies to mobile catering, food trucks, burger vans, and trailers.

Key Facts

Detail	Information
Cost	**FREE**
When to register	At least 28 days before you start trading
Who to register with	The council where your vehicle is stored overnight
How many times	Once only — even if you trade in multiple areas

How to Register

1. Visit **gov.uk/food-business-registration**
2. Enter your home postcode (where vehicle is stored)
3. You'll be directed to your local council's registration page
4. Complete the online form
5. You'll receive confirmation within 28 days

What You'll Need

- Business name and address
- Name of food business operator
- Type of food business (mobile catering)
- Vehicle storage address
- Planned opening date

✓ **Pro Tip:** Keep a copy of your registration confirmation in your van. Environmental Health Officers may ask to see it during inspections.

3. Food Hygiene Certification

What You Need

Level 2 Food Hygiene Certificate — the industry standard for anyone handling food.

Detail	Information
Duration	2–3 hours online
Cost	£10–£25
Validity	Recommended to refresh every 3 years
Certificate	Instant digital certificate on completion

What You'll Learn

- Personal hygiene and handwashing
- Food storage temperatures
- Cross-contamination prevention
- Cleaning procedures
- Allergen awareness

Recommended Providers

Provider	Cost	Duration
High Speed Training	£20 +VAT	2 hours
Food Safety UK	£10 +VAT	3 hours
Train4Academy	£15 +VAT	2–3 hours
CPD Online	£12 +VAT	2 hours

💡 **Tip:** Choose a course that's CPD accredited and/or RoSPA approved — these are accepted by all UK local authorities.

4. Food Safety Management System

What It Is

A documented system showing how you keep food safe. Required by law under EU Regulation 852/2004.

Safer Food Better Business (SFBB)

The Food Standards Agency provides a **FREE** pack designed specifically for caterers. It's based on HACCP principles but written in plain English.

The 4 Cs

Your system must cover:

Principle	What It Means
Cooking	Ensuring food reaches safe temperatures
Cleaning	Keeping surfaces, equipment, and hands clean
Chilling	Storing food at correct temperatures
Cross-contamination	Preventing raw food contaminating ready-to-eat food

What's in the SFBB Pack

- Safe methods (laminated sheets)
- 4-weekly diary
- Cleaning schedule template
- Temperature recording logs
- Training records

> 📩 **Free Download:**
> **food.gov.uk/business-guidance/safer-food-better-business**

Digital Alternative

SFBB+ App — a digital version that makes record-keeping easier. Available on iOS and Android.

5. Gas Safety Certificate (CP44)

What It Is

If your catering vehicle uses LPG (bottled gas), you need an annual gas safety inspection and certificate.

Detail	Information
Certificate type	CP44 (Mobile Catering Gas Safety)
Cost	£80–£150 typically
Frequency	Annual (every 12 months)
Who can issue	Gas Safe registered engineer with commercial catering qualifications

What's Inspected

- LPG cylinder storage and ventilation
- Gas pipework and connections
- Appliance condition and operation
- Extraction and ventilation
- Carbon monoxide levels
- Emergency shut-off valve

LPG Storage Rules

⚠️ **Legal Requirements:**

- Cylinders must be stored in a **separate compartment** from the cooking area
- If outside the vehicle, keep in a cage **minimum 1 metre from any structure**
- Warning notice must be displayed on the enclosure
- Never store cylinders inside your trading area

Finding an Engineer

1. **Gas Safe Register:** gassaferegister.co.uk — search for engineers with "Commercial Catering" and "LPG" qualifications
2. **NCASS recommended engineers:** Ask in the NCASS member community
3. **Local suppliers:** Commercial catering equipment suppliers often offer inspection services

6. Street Trading Licence

What It Is

Permission to sell food from public land (streets, pavements, council-owned car parks). **Not needed** if trading on private land with owner's permission.

Types of Consent

Type	Description
Street Trading Licence	Fixed location, typically 12 months
Street Trading Consent	Temporary or occasional trading
Market Trader Licence	For trading at council markets

Key Facts

- **Varies by council** — each has different rules, fees, and availability
- **Some councils have banned street trading** entirely — check before buying!
- **Processing time:** 4–8 weeks typically
- **Cost:** £100–£500/year (varies hugely)

Example Costs (2025/26)

Council	Annual Fee
Newham	£110 application
Westminster	£400–£1,200+
Birmingham	£200–£400

If Street Trading Isn't Available

Alternatives:

- Private land agreements — car parks, pub gardens, industrial estates
- Event pitches — festivals, markets, sports grounds
- Business parks — negotiate with landlords/management companies
- Pubs and venues — partnership arrangements

7. Insurance Requirements

Essential Cover

Type	What It Covers	Required?
Public Liability	Injury/damage to third parties	Yes (most events require it)
Products Liability	Illness from your food	Yes (essential)
Employers Liability	Staff injuries	Yes (if you have staff)
Vehicle Insurance	Your van/trailer	Yes (legal requirement)
Contents/Equipment	Your catering equipment	Recommended

⚠️ **Important:** Most events, markets, and landlords require **minimum £5 million** public liability cover.

Recommended Providers

Provider	Cover	Annual Cost
CMTIA	£5m Public & Products	From £65
NCASS Insurance	Comprehensive	From £200
Simply Business	£2m Public Liability	From £68
Mobilers	Tailored packages	Quote-based

Provider Websites

- **CMTIA** — cmtia.co.uk (specialist mobile catering insurer)
- **NCASS Insurance** — ncassinsurance.co.uk (trade body insurance)
- **Mobilers** — mobilers.co.uk (mobile catering specialists)

- **Simply Business** — simplybusiness.co.uk (quick online quotes)

8. Finding Pitch Locations

Types of Pitches

Type	Pros	Cons
Street trading (council)	Consistent location, foot traffic	Competitive, licence needed
Private land	Flexible, negotiate direct	Need landowner permission
Industrial estates	Captive audience (workers)	Limited to lunch hours
Events & festivals	High volume, premium prices	Pitch fees, seasonal
Pub car parks	Built-in customers	Revenue share expected

How to Find Pitches

1. Industrial Estates & Business Parks

- Drive around local industrial areas
- Note businesses with no canteen
- Approach landlords/management companies
- Offer to serve workers at lunch

2. Pub Partnerships

- Approach pubs without kitchens
- Offer food service in their car park/garden
- Typical arrangement: rent-free in exchange for driving drink sales

3. Private Car Parks

- Supermarket car parks (permission needed)
- Retail park service areas
- Sports clubs and gyms
- Farm shops

🚐 Ready to Find Your Van?

Browse verified catering vehicles from trusted sellers

catertrades.com/browse

9. Events & Festivals

Types of Events

Event Type	Typical Fee	Potential Earnings
Small local festival	£100–£300	£500–£2,000
Major music festival	£500–£2,000+	£3,000–£15,000+
Food festival	£200–£500	£1,000–£5,000
Corporate event	Negotiable	£400–£600 minimum
Weddings	£400–£800	£400–£1,500

Where to Find Events

- **eventbrite.co.uk** — search for food festivals
- **festivalsuk.com**
- **eFestivals.co.uk**
- Facebook events in your area
- Contact festival organisers directly (usually 6–12 months ahead)

Application Tips

1. **Apply early** — popular events fill up 6–12 months ahead
2. **Professional photos** — show your unit and food
3. **Unique menu** — stand out from burger/pizza competition
4. **Dietary options** — vegan/GF options increase bookings
5. **References** — list events you've done before
6. **Insurance proof** — have certificates ready to attach

Festival Season Calendar

Month	Events
May–June	Spring festivals, food festivals
July–August	Peak festival season
September	Harvest festivals, food markets
Oct–Nov	Bonfire nights, Halloween events
December	Christmas markets

10. Useful Resources & Contacts

Official Resources

Resource	Website
Food business registration	gov.uk/food-business-registration
Safer Food Better Business pack	food.gov.uk/sfbb
Gas Safe Register	gassaferegister.co.uk
Street trading info	Your local council website

Trade Associations

Organisation	Benefits
NCASS (Nationwide Caterers Association)	Insurance, legal advice, classifieds, community ncass.org.uk
Mobile Food Alliance	Marketplace, resources mobilefoodalliance.com

Useful Apps

App	Purpose
SFBB+	Digital food safety records
Indi Local	Find events and connect with venues
Square / SumUp	Card payments
Xero / QuickBooks	Accounting

Facebook Groups (Search for)

- "UK Street Food Vendors"
- "Catering Trailer Owners UK"
- "Food Truck Life UK"
- "Mobile Catering Buy & Sell"

Emergency Contacts

Gas emergency	0800 111 999
Food Standards Agency	0330 332 7149

Quick Reference Card

Print this page and keep it in your van

✅ Daily Checks

- ☐ Gas connections secure
- ☐ Fridge at 5°C or below
- ☐ Handwashing facilities working
- ☐ Fresh sanitiser solution
- ☐ Clean serving area

🌡️ Safe Temperatures

Fridge	0–5°C
Freezer	-18°C or below
Hot holding	63°C or above
Reheated food	75°C core

📞 Emergency Contacts

Gas emergency	0800 111 999
Food Standards Agency	0330 332 7149
Your council EHO	_____
Insurance provider	_____

🚐 **Find Your Perfect Catering Vehicle**

Browse verified vans, trucks, and trailers from trusted sellers across the UK

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